



MONTHLY UPDATE

Access to services: monthly update, August 2026

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ALGERIA · ANGOLA · BOTSWANA · BURUNDI · COTE D'IVOIRE · DR CONGO · EGYPT · ESWATINI · GHANA · KENYA · LIBYA · MADAGASCAR · MALAWI · MALI · MOZAMBIQUE · NAMIBIA · NIGERIA · SENEGAL · SEYCHELLES · SIERRA LEONE · SOUTH AFRICA · TANZANIA · UGANDA · ZIMBABWE

Algeria

Consumer cloud storage prices were [raised for new subscribers from 27 July 2026](#), in this market alongside two others on the continent. One provider's consumer tariff is thin evidence for affordability, and the account gives no local subscriber base against which to read it. It is recorded because it is the only dated consumer cloud price the base holds here, and a price that moves is more use than a market with no price at all.

Angola

The identity-card universalisation programme is being reported by throughput: [more than 4,000 cards issued in one municipality in sixteen days](#), with no national total, backlog figure or target date beside it.

The telecommunications ministry [opened further computer rooms and free public internet points in Luanda and Icolo e Bengo](#). No national count of sites, users or budget line is on file behind the programme.

Botswana

The Ministry of Youth and Gender Affairs [describes the Department of Gender Affairs as secretariat to the National Gender Commission](#), the standing institution behind this subject. Nothing else in the inclusion ledger moved in this window; the gender-based violence programme and the one-stop centres both date from earlier in the year.

Burundi

A rural community digital hub [opened at Shombo](#). It is a single site reported by its own organisers; no programme, national count, funding line or usage figure stands behind it.

Cote d'Ivoire

Access moved by putting the counter where people already are. The civil-registry agency [opened an office inside a Yopougon shopping centre on 14 August](#). It is one site, with no opening hours, service list or plan for further locations published.

DR Congo

On 23 July a state bank and the payroll monitoring committee settled the technical and organisational terms for [paying civil servants in rural territories, scoped to three named territories and others where no other bank operates](#). August 2026 was named as a target, with the bank's director-general calling a fixed date premature and the state contract unsigned. What subscribers pay moved the other way. Users and resellers in Bukavu say a [1GB bundle that ran 48 hours at 1,500 Congolese francs now expires in 24 at the same price](#), and a 2GB 48-hour bundle at 2,000 francs has been replaced by 1GB over 72 hours; subscribers across the eastern provinces [report the same pattern across four operators and have asked a consumer body to intervene](#). Both ends are subscribers' accounts; no operator or regulator has stated anything.

Egypt

The month's clearest inclusion move was a reopening rather than an extension. From 24 July the state accepted ration-card grievance and data-update forms at 500 post offices on Friday afternoons and Saturday mornings, alongside the online route that had until then been the only channel for appeals against the 2026 eligibility criteria, with a daily adjudication committee, results notified by text message and every case checked against official databases.

Eswatini

The country's second innovation hub opened at [Macetjeni in the Lubombo region on 7 August, extending digital-skills and small-business support to a rural community](#), built by the small enterprise development company with the communications commission and UNDP under a youth empowerment programme, and following the Piggs Peak hub of 2025. No financing figure was disclosed for the facility, and no user, training or enterprise-support count is published for either.

What firms say they need is not more hubs but a network that stays up. At a Mbabane panel on 7 August, logistics, renewable-energy and creator-economy speakers [argued that unreliable connectivity is now a direct cost to business, outweighing any saving from cheaper data](#), describing real-time fleet tracking, remote solar-system monitoring and social-platform market access as core to operations, and urged investment in rural connectivity to widen economic participation. It is a panel of interested parties, and the base holds no reliability series to test it against.

Ghana

The mid-year fiscal review of 23 July recorded GH¢485m paid to cash-grant beneficiaries in the first half of 2026 and named no allocation at all to the communications ministry, the access fund, the coders programme or the artificial-intelligence strategy.

Kenya

The Auditor-General's findings on the Hustler Fund entered the record on 23 July: [104,631 loans worth KSh 116.5m](#) were issued to borrowers whose national identity details were missing from the customer database, against a 15% default rate and state funding down to KSh 300m in the year to June 2026.

Libya

On 5 August a Central Bank source told Libya Herald that cash distribution to commercial bank branches would begin on 9 August under an August operational plan, with [withdrawal limits starting at LD 3,000 per customer and LD 4,000 in the south](#), subject to increase as liquidity allows.

Madagascar

The month's only market measurement came from an operator: MVola's director general put the whole Malagasy mobile-money market at [six to seven million active users against a population of about thirty million, with rural areas under-served](#), and set doubling or tripling that as the five-to-ten-year test.

Malawi

The first usable figure for how many Malawians are online came from the operators' own trade association rather than from the state. Its report [puts 80% of the population offline despite 87% 4G population coverage, and estimates MWK 1.1 trillion of economic value and 490,000 jobs by 2030 from closing the usage gap](#), setting out six policy priorities for the government and the regulator. The gap it identifies is usage and not coverage, which is a finding the base had no measurement for; the value estimate is modelled by an interested party, and among the six asks is cutting the mobile-service taxes its members pay. Against it stands [a presidential target of 80% internet usage by 2026](#) that has never had a published baseline.

Mali

The month's one measure of what connectivity costs a Malian is a comparison with the neighbour. About [1.5GB of mobile data in Bamako buys what 25GB buys in Dakar](#) — a ratio of roughly 25 to 1, which critics attribute to weak market oversight by the regulator, the duopoly of the two incumbent operators, and the years since a new operator licence was issued. It is a press comparison rather than a regulator or operator tariff series, and neither the basket nor the date of the prices compared is stated; taken at its own weight it still sits awkwardly against the digital-sovereignty case the same month's fora were built around.

Mozambique

The central bank's Financial Inclusion Report 2025, reported on 24 July, counted 482,359 financial access points, up 36% on 2024, of which 446,604 were non-bank agents against 315,005 the year before, while automated teller machines fell from 1,391 to 1,383 and card terminals from 35,486 to 32,236 ([report account](#)). [Mobile money reached 1,313 accounts per thousand adults against 337 bank accounts, and the national Financial Inclusion Index held flat at 36.4 points](#). Agent growth was fastest in the least-served provinces, and the report set that against a widening credit gap: women's participation in credit rose from 31% to 34% while men's rose from 59% to 66%, even as women's mobile money holding rose 24%.

August added the price side of the same picture. A standard data package [fell from 9.4% of monthly gross national income per head in 2022 to 2.67% in March 2026](#), on World Bank Digital Acceleration Project figures released with the coverage map. The basket behind the standard package is not defined in the record held.

What none of these measures reaches is what the money does. A study of 900 households published on 7 August finds that [mobile money improves household welfare through active use rather than account ownership, reducing reliance on own food production and strengthening resilience through remittances, with women gaining financial autonomy and young people using it to stabilise consumption](#). It is a single academic study of a sample, not a national series, and it is the only evidence of outcome the base holds against the access counts above.

A commercial bank [opened its mobile banking application to customers without consuming their mobile data balances or packages](#). Zero-rating a single private application raises a net-neutrality question the base holds no ruling on, and no user count or operator agreement is published behind it.

Namibia

The central bank's deputy governor told the payments association's annual general meeting on 28 July that financial inclusion rose from 78% in 2017 to 86% in 2025, and named continued cash reliance, limited rural access, informal-sector barriers and the digital divide as the persistent constraints ([central bank account](#)).

Education added a channel built for the same margins. The education ministry and UNICEF [launched a Namibia Learning Passport, a digital and offline learning platform aimed at rural, remote and underserved young people](#), at the international youth day event in Keetmanshoop. No user target, content catalogue, device requirement or offline distribution route is stated — which matters most for the platform's stated audience, since parliamentary evidence in the same window put schools and clinics in Kavango West as substantially cut off from reliable internet.

What that looks like in one region was put to the parliamentary ICT committee on 11 August: [21 of Kavango West's 188 schools have workable connectivity, leaving 55,002 learners without digital teaching tools](#), and health officials told the same committee that clinics there still struggle with unreliable mobile coverage. The figures are the regional education director's own, and they sit against a target of full telecommunications coverage by 2030.

Nigeria

A [digital self-care platform went live for University of Lagos students](#), routing to free contraceptives through the state health ministry and UNFPA supply chain, with expansion to other Lagos campuses planned.

Away from the campuses, German cooperation [opened a tender on 4 August for the IT equipment of rural job centres in Ogun and Plateau States](#), under a youth-employment project. A procurement notice fixes the equipment stage and nothing else: how many centres, at what cost, and when they open are all unstated.

The accessibility requirement is not reaching the platforms it binds. [None of eight public websites audited in May 2026, among them the admissions board, the identity commission, the revenue service and the disability commission itself, had implemented baseline accessibility features](#); an earlier assessment of all 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory found 26 non-compliant with the technology agency's website guidelines and 14 sites unusable for people with disabilities; and the Nigeria Web Design Standards, launched in July 2025 with a toolkit promised within eight to ten weeks, had published none by August 2026 with no evidence of Federal Executive Council approval or of implementation. The commission's own estimate is 35 million Nigerians with disabilities.

Senegal

The flagship access programme is under investigation. The National Assembly [voted 129-0 to open a commission of inquiry into about 48 billion FCFA committed since 2017 under the student-computer programme, over alleged procurement breaches and 800 defective machines stored unused at the country's largest university](#). Nine years in, the programme publishes no delivery total, unit cost or student-reach figure, so the inquiry's envelope is the only quantity the record holds about it.

Seychelles

The same survey puts a number on demand for open government, which the Access to Information Act reform has been drafted against since November 2025 without a Bill reaching Parliament. [62% say the public should have access to government information, against 25% who say it is for officials only](#); support is strongest where the information is fiscal — [84% for district-administration budgets and 82% for bids and contracts on government projects](#) — and falls to 47% for the salaries of district administrators and teachers.

Sierra Leone

Financial inclusion is put at [about 40% of adults for 2025](#). It is a named analyst's assessment rather than an official series, and the base holds no state measurement to set beside it.

The cost of the handset is being financed rather than reduced. An operator and a commercial bank [opened a 24-month device-financing scheme to individual and business customers, on top of their existing prepaid card relationship](#). No price, interest rate, eligibility test or uptake figure is stated.

South Africa

The South African Social Security Agency [set 350,000 grant reviews for 2026/27](#) against a projected R1.5bn saving, while beneficiaries flagged from September 2025 [reported continued non-payment](#). An account of the digitalised grants system published on 25 July set out the [bank-account means test applied across eight grants](#), which remains in operation under appeal, with the Supreme Court of Appeal hearing set for 25 August 2026. Gold Cards were confirmed to [cease functioning after 31 August](#); the position of beneficiaries who miss the deadline was not stated.

One cooperation arrangement addressed a group the grants system serves and the data rarely describes. South Africa and China [agreed a seven-point plan on disability-inclusive data, universal design and artificial-intelligence-enabled assistive technology](#), anchored in a proposed centre of excellence working with the national statistics office. No instrument, funding, timetable or data-sharing arrangement is published for cooperation that names the statistics office as a partner.

The state's own IT agency was told why it cannot deliver. The Public Service Commission's investigation of government IT procurement over 2020 to 2025 found [86% of managing-director roles held on an acting or interim basis, board tenures too short for strategic continuity, and irregular expenditure above R2bn across four audited years read as control failure through absent deterrence](#); the agency told Parliament in August it is finalising executive recruitment, naming no appointment or date, while some of the hundred-plus departments it carries look elsewhere.

The grant-review audit reached [105,600 of 352,000 targeted reviews with an estimated R450-million saved](#), while suspending lawful beneficiaries' payments without effective notice. The saving is the agency's own estimate; the suspensions are reported against it.

Tanzania

Access moved for a group the digital estate rarely reaches. The central bank [launched Braille editions of its publications in Dar es Salaam on 20 August](#). It is a print accommodation rather than a digital one, and no equivalent screen-reader or accessible-format commitment for the bank's online material is on the record.

Uganda

At a readiness inspection on 27 July, [six of nineteen planned one-stop service centres were recorded as operational](#), with three pilots funded through the Uganda Digital Acceleration Project and centre throughput made contingent on the fifth phase of the national backbone.

An [ICT hub for persons with disabilities was commissioned in Kasese](#), reported on 1 August, offering computer literacy, vocational skills and digital-empowerment programmes and open to the wider community. No commitment value was published, so the base carries no finance record for it.

The commercial route to a connected device is credit. Buy-now-pay-later schemes run by five providers [put smartphones in the hands of more than 500,000 Ugandans in a year, against about 22% of Ugandans using mobile internet despite 96% network coverage, with financed devices costing 30 to 50% more than the cash price](#). It is a trade analysis rather than a regulator series, and no default, repossession or total-cost-of-credit figure is published for the schemes.

A six-year donor digital-inclusion programme [ended, with stakeholders urging the government to take over what it was doing](#). No successor instrument, budget line or transfer of assets is on file, which makes the closure a stated exposure rather than an inference.

Zimbabwe

The health minister told the National Assembly on 17 July that more than 400 health facilities had received satellite kits with 300 more to be added, but that subscriptions had not been paid because the fees were too high ([National Assembly account](#)).

At a payments conference on 24 July a research firm reported that 95% of transport payments remain cash, that 56% of respondents found digital systems complicated with people with disabilities particularly affected ([conference account](#)).

A media institute's August review sets the country's headline connectivity figure against what it costs. It records [internet penetration at 84.55% on the regulator's fourth-quarter 2025 data, many households spending more than 10% of income to be online against the United Nations' 2% benchmark, and only 62% of the population with reliable electricity](#), and asks whether the 2026-2030 artificial-intelligence strategy can be delivered on those foundations. The penetration figure counts active subscriptions rather than individual users, which is the gap the affordability finding sits in.

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